restoration of large-scale property, increasing privatisation, reinforcing the preeminence of profit, and assuring the supremacy of the market over planning. It can be debated whether or not this process has been concluded or is irreversible, but its depth and its regressive social consequences are plain for all to see. Authors who underline this retreat are able to present a more realistic picture than those who interpret this process as a variety of 'market socialism'.[5]

Confusion over emerging economies

Some countries remain classified along with China in the same bloc of emerging economies. India, Brazil and Russia are especially included in this column. But this grouping ignores the fact that China's economy is two-and-a-half times bigger than India's and four times bigger than that of Brazil or Russia. Moreover, its growth rates have been much higher and its accumulated reserves far surpass the sum of all three of these nations combined.[6] These distinctions are compounded by a very different insertion into the international economy. While China directly impacts the flow of the global circuit, these other countries have only a secondary influence. The decisive aid China's central bank extended to the Triad during the crisis contrasted sharply with the absence of any sort of gravitational pull displayed by the other three countries. This group is located closer to the camp seeking aid than the camp offering it. Nor have these three countries been the recipients of the general transfer of industry which has moved toward the Far East.

The most recent classifications also include Turkey and South Africa among the emerging economies. They have undergone expansion over the last decade, suffering only limited effects from the recent crisis and a milder debt problem when compared to the developed economies. Yet the growth rates for these economies have been variable and very uncertain, and they are based on relatively recent developments and not on changes accumulated over several decades. Still other countries located in the emerging sector have grown as a consequence of higher international prices for raw materials. The long-term structural, and not merely financial, changes behind this higher valorisation do not alter the vulnerability of these countries, which remain so dependent on commodity fluctuations.

Grouping all these under the same heading of emerging economies only multiplies confusion. The category itself is based on short-term financial considerations. The acronym BRICS, for example, was introduced by a trader at Goldman Sachs to point out investment opportunities. Using this same logic, other financial analysts have walked away from the BRICS and are preparing to